

Politics

Ursula von der Leyen, the European Commission's president, invited Canada to become the European Union's first associate member. In the EU's state-of-the-union address she told Canadian prime minister Mark Carney that the partnership would be "for our common strength". Canada has sought closer ties to the bloc as its trade war with America worsens. Donald Trump called the proposal "laughable" and threatened the EU with "serious tariffs".

Russian drones hit a stationary Ukrainian locomotive and a petrol station near the Polish border approximately an hour after a train carrying top Western officials passed through the area. Andrii Sybiha, Ukraine's foreign minister, called the strike "Putin's terror knocking...on the doors of the EU and NATO".

Magdalena Andersson, the leader of Sweden's Social Democrats, looked likely to become the country's next prime minister after an agonisingly close election on September 13th. Ms Andersson's left-wing bloc—which includes small-state centrists, environmentalists and leftist-populists—was set to take 176 seats, compared with 173 for the government and its allies. The populist-right Sweden Democrats, who have supported the centre-right government since 2022, lost support for the first time since they entered parliament in 2010.

A pair of record-breaking donations to Reform UK prompted calls for an overhaul of funding in British politics. Christopher Harborne and Ben Delo, British crypto billionaires who used to live in Asia, said they would each give £36m (\$48m) to the populist-right party led by Nigel Farage. Politicians from other parties now want to tighten the rules, perhaps even rendering Reform UK's windfall illegal.

Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, said that he would sue Haaretz, a liberal Israeli newspaper, for publishing claims that days before October 7th 2023 the leader of the United Arab Emirates warned him in a phone call that Hamas, the Islamists in Gaza, were preparing to attack. Mr Netanyahu's office said that the reports were part of a "sinister plot" and that the prime minister had received no such warning.

The Houthis, Iran-backed rebels in Yemen, advanced down the country's western coast. They captured Mokha, a port city, and seized Perim island, a rocky outcrop in the middle of Bab al-Mandab, the strait that links the Red Sea to the Indian Ocean. In July the Houthis announced a blockade on Saudi shipping through the Red Sea.

Meanwhile, drones hit Saudi Arabia's east-west pipeline which can carry up to 7m barrels per day to the kingdom's Red Sea ports. It was shut down "as a precautionary measure". The Saudi foreign ministry blamed the attack on militias in Iraq. The closure saw the price of Brent crude, the international oil benchmark, rise above \$109 a barrel. Saudi Arabia said it shot down a Houthi drone south of the holy city of Mecca.

China accused American tech bosses of "fearmongering" over their calls to limit its ability to develop AI. Dario Amodei, the chief executive of Anthropic, called for a slowdown in AI development. He warned that a Chinese lead "would pose grave danger" for America and the world. China's foreign ministry said such comments were counterproductive and would limit options for global AI governance.

The winner takes it all

Donald Trump said America must remain ahead of China in AI as he rejected a chorus of calls for a slowdown and greater regulation. Steve Bannon, a former Trump adviser, and Bernie Sanders, a socialist Democrat, united in a speech to warn of the need for greater oversight of the technology. Mr Trump has said "whoever wins AI wins" and dismissed concerns that it poses a risk to humanity as "a hoax".

Mr Trump hit out at America's Supreme Court for rejecting his attempt to restrict postal voting ahead of November's midterms. The president wrote on Truth Social, his social-media platform, that the court was "bullied and cajoled by the

Radical Left". He has repeated claims, without evidence, that postal voting is prone to fraud.

America's Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) will scrap limits on greenhouse-gas emissions from coal- and gas-fired power plants. The head of the EPA said that reversing the Biden-administration requirements that plants reduce pollution by using technologies like carbon capture and storage would save Americans \$310bn. Power plants are America's second-biggest source of CO2 emissions.

America paid \$725m in dues to the United Nations, averting the possibility that it could lose its vote in the UN General Assembly for skipping two-years' worth of membership fees. The payment, made for the 2025 budget, was overdue. The Trump administration had halted contributions to push for changes to some UN agencies and priorities.

Police in the Philippines said it could take months to identify victims from a ferry fire that killed at least 76 people. The MV June Aster was travelling from Manila to Coron, a popular tourist destination, when the fire broke out. The cause of the blaze has not yet been identified.

China's president Xi Jinping attended the BRICS summit in New Delhi on his first trip to India for seven years. Mr Xi met Indian prime minister Narendra Modi on the side-lines of the event in a further warming of relations between the countries following a border dispute in 2020.

Third time lucky

Prabowo Subianto, Indonesia's president, appointed his third finance minister in two years. Mr Prabowo replaced Purbaya Yudhi Sadewa with his deputy, Suhasil Nazara, in a bid to restore economic credibility. Mr Purbaya, who was in office for a year, spooked investors by calling the IMF "stupid" and with his comments about the effects of rising oil prices on the global economy.

The UN Security Council voted unanimously to extend the arms embargo on Sudan's western Darfur region for another month. America backed away from forcing a vote to extend the embargo to the whole country, but said it would not "rubber-stamp" a further extension to a Darfur-only embargo. The United Arab Emirates, which is accused of sending weapons to the Rapid Support Forces in Darfur in violation of the restrictions, has been lobbying to extend the ban across the whole country.

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